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All through the second wave, there were media stories doing the rounds about an acute shortage of ventilators. All through 2020, the GoI along with private organizations had strived to meet the increased demand with funds allocated from PM CARES. Out of the total 60,000 units ordered, 49,960 ventilators had been sent to the states before the second wave and about 12,000 were dispatched during the second wave. Surprised to see stories of shortage, the prime minister ordered an immediate audit to look into reasons why the ventilators sent to the states were not put to use. Noticing that the states were crying foul about the quality of the ventilators, the MoHFW secretary had written to the states on 9 and 13 May,

> It has been found that there is a large gap between ventilators delivered and installed. It is understood that the non-installation is primarily on account of large number of them lying in warehouses, delay in allocation, preparing location for installation, absence of connectors with hospitals, lack of piped oxygen electrical fittings and trained manpower. In a number of hospitals the sites are not ready for ventilator installation. This includes lack of availability of piped oxygen supply system or lack of optimum oxygen pressure in the pipe system or even proper electrical fittings. It is again reiterated that the states may sensitize the consignee hospitals to ensure provisioning requisite number of ventilator connectors so that once the ventilators reach the hospitals their installation and commissioning does not get delayed.[50]

On the other side, the media was rife with stories about faulty ventilators provided to them by the Centre which had rendered the units useless. However, the audit brought to light several inadequacies on the part of states to use them appropriately. Let us consider the example below: Punjab and Rajasthan, both Congress-run states, first raised the issue of receiving faulty ventilators from the Centre. Punjab was first supplied about 100 ventilators in October 2020. The manufacturer of those ventilators, Jyoti CNC reached out to the Punjab government several times asking where they would want the units to be installed. During a video conference with the Punjab government officials, the latter apparently claimed that they didn’t need the ventilators and that they should be taken back. By April 2021,